



GDD 55 Equal Partners

From "helping" to owning your half.

The equal-home heart of Chapter 7. The most unequal place in most lives is the home, so this tackles the most stubborn inequality of all: the unequal division of housework, caregiving and the invisible "mental load". It helps a couple build a genuinely equal partnership across chores, care, money-time and decisions, with both careers respected, and its signature move is reframing men's role from "helping" to owning an equal share. Even-handed, never anti-men. Seven mechanics, 29 choice-and-voice moments, zero "tap the right card". Scorecard: passed.

The equal home.

Equal Partners takes Equalize's "second shift" lesson into the real stakes of a shared adult life. It tackles the most stubborn inequality of all, the unequal division of housework, caregiving and the invisible "mental load" at home, and helps a couple build a genuinely equal partnership across chores, care, money-time and decisions, with both careers respected. Its signature move is reframing the role from "helping" to owning an equal share, the planning and remembering, not just the chores. It is even-handed, engaging men as equal owners, never anti-men, and never shames any current arrangement. New v2 build, the precursor to Equal Parents (g62).

FIELD	VALUE
Node / gameld	g55 · equal-partners (confirm exact id against engine-host)
Chapter / ages	Chapter 7 · 22 → first child · adult / even-handed / practical
Thread / topics	E · Gender & Respect · UNESCO 3.2, 1.1, 5.3
Prerequisite / builds on	g54 · builds on g26 (Equalize) · precursor to g62 · links g56
Gating	Open · even-handed; men as equal owners
Schema / status	v2 · scorecard PASS the equal-home game.

84

scenarios

7

mechanics

15

myth-flips

29

choice & voice

0%

binary taps

"Helping" isn't sharing; owning is. When one partner "helps", the other stays the manager who notices, plans, delegates and remembers, the invisible mental load. India has one of the world's largest unpaid-care gaps, women do around 2.6 times more unpaid care than men even in dual-income homes, and that invisible labour drives real burnout. The fix is concrete: make the whole load visible, own whole domains end-to-end so no one has to be reminded, value both careers equally, and renegotiate as life changes, because an equal home is happier for everyone.

Name the load. Move from helping to owning.

From the Chapter 7 personas (22 onward). The partner carrying the invisible second shift, and the "good guy who helps" but can't yet see it, met with a tool to make the load visible and a clear path from helping to owning, never with shame.

PERSONA	WHAT THEY NEED HERE	THE MECHANIC THAT SERVES IT
Pooja, 27	The mental load named out loud, and a fairer split.	strike-rewrite + sort : see the load.
Karthik, 29	To move from "helping" to genuinely owning his half.	strike-rewrite + role-play : helping vs owning.
Both partners	A fair, explicit, renegotiated split.	branch + match : share it & keep it.
Dual-career couples	That whose job flexes isn't decided by gender.	strike-rewrite + branch : two careers.

Why this works (the evidence). Beyond the visible chores is the invisible mental load, the constant cognitive and emotional work of planning, remembering, anticipating and worrying, which falls overwhelmingly on women; in India women do around 2.6 times more unpaid care than men even in dual-income urban homes, and this invisible labour predicts cognitive overload and burnout. The key shift is from "helping" to owning: a helper waits to be asked, leaving the manager role with the woman, while an owner notices, plans and does a whole domain without being asked, so the need to remind disappears. Both careers count equally, so whose job flexes should never default to gender. And equality is built, an explicit, agreed, fair split, revisited as life changes, and an equal home is happier and healthier for everyone, men included.

Seven moves, led by the choice and the flip.

It's a load-sharing game, so **branch** leads (choose to own, to split fairly, to renegotiate), with **strike-rewrite** clearing the "helping = sharing" myths and **role-play** for the equality conversations. Mechanics rotate; the same one never runs twice in a row.

MECHANIC	THE ADULT DOES	EMBODIES	N
branch (the choice) signature	Chooses to own a domain, split fairly, or renegotiate.	Ownership.	18
strike-rewrite	Busts a load myth ("helping means sharing equally").	Conceptual change.	15
sort	Sorts visible vs invisible; owning vs helping; fair vs default.	The line.	14
reflect	Internalises seeing the load and owning a fair share.	Values.	12
role-play (voice)	Reframes "helping"; opens the split talk; renegotiates.	Voice; ownership.	11
spot	Spots the hidden mental-load task, the imbalance, the fair split.	Reading it.	7
match	Pairs a load type to an example; a tool to its job.	Connections.	7

29 of 84 moments are branch or role-play. Binary "tap the right answer": **0%**.

The two-test, passed.

Is it engaging?

Game feel is recognition and relief: the naming of an exhaustion that had no words ("the mental load"), the lightbulb of the helping-vs-owning distinction, and the satisfaction of a balancing-act where a fair, owned split finally clicks into place. For the partner carrying it, being seen lands hard; for the "good guy who helps", the shift from "how can I help?" to "this is mine" is a genuine reframe. Sam is an even-handed adult peer; the tone engages men as equal owners and never shames anyone's current setup.

Is it teaching?

Yes: seeing and naming the full domestic and care load, including the mental load; negotiating a fair, explicit division with a partner; reframing "helping" as owning; valuing both careers equally so whose job flexes isn't gendered; and keeping equality a living, renegotiated conversation, with the truth that an equal home is happier for everyone.

The belief it moves. From "the mental load isn't real work; helping equals sharing; doing it when asked is my share; her career should flex; once we agree a split it's sorted" → "the mental load is real, exhausting work; owning beats helping; owning means not needing to be asked; both careers count; and equality is renegotiated as life changes."

Built, not bolted on.

84 researched scenarios across the see-the-load → helping-vs-owning → share-it-fairly → two-careers → keep-it-equal → tools arc, India-grounded and even-handed. Full library in the companion JSON.

CATEGORY	N	LEAD MECHANICS	COVERS
See the whole load	15	strike-rewrite, sort, spot	The invisible mental load; the second shift.
Helping vs owning	15	strike-rewrite, branch, role-play	Own a domain end-to-end, don't just help.
Share it fairly	15	branch, sort, role-play	The explicit, agreed, fair split; all hours counted.
Two careers	13	strike-rewrite, branch, sort	Whose job flexes isn't gender; both count.
Keep it equal	12	branch, role-play, reflect	Renegotiate as life changes; everyone gains.
Tools & help	14	match, sort, reflect	Fair-split & mental-load tool; links to help.

The 'helping = sharing' flip + an owning role-play, verbatim.

```
flip: "Helping with the chores means I'm sharing the load equally."
UN -> "Helping with the chores means I share the load equally."
RE -> "'Helping' leaves your partner as the manager; true equality is owning a domain."

role-play (owning): your partner keeps thanking you for 'helping'.
best -> "This isn't me helping you, it's mine to run, you shouldn't
        have to manage it."
```

Full library: [SwipeEd — GDD 55 Equal Partners — Scenario Library.json](#) (84 records, v2 schema).

What this game flips.

MYTH (UN ERASES)	TRUTH (RE WRITES)	BASIS
The mental load isn't real work.	Planning, remembering and anticipating is real, exhausting cognitive labour.	Mental load.
We split chores 50/50, so we're equal.	Visible chores are only part of it; the invisible load must be shared too.	Whole load.
Helping with chores means I'm sharing equally.	"Helping" leaves your partner managing; true equality is owning a domain.	Owning.
If I do the task when asked, I've done my share.	Being asked means they still carry the load; own it without being asked.	Without asking.
Asking him to remember things is just nagging.	The need to remind is the unequal load; owning removes it.	Not nagging.
Her career is the one that should flex.	Whose career flexes shouldn't default to gender; both count equally.	Two careers.
Housework and childcare are naturally the woman's job.	They're shared work; nothing about them is "naturally" gendered.	Not gendered.
An equal home is a women's demand and a loss for men.	An equal home is happier and healthier for everyone, men included.	Everyone gains.

The micro-loop.

1. **Surface.** Sam (even-handed peer) surfaces a real moment, a "thanks for helping", an exhausted partner, a flexing career.
2. **Choose or voice.** The adult chooses to own, split fairly or renegotiate (branch), or finds the words (role-play).
3. **The flip.** UN busts a load myth; RE writes the owning truth.
4. **See, share, keep.** Make the load visible; own domains; value both careers; renegotiate as life changes.
5. **Tools & help.** A fair-split and mental-load tool; coercive inequality routes to Respect at Home (g56) and help.
6. **Sticker.** The Equal-Partners badge; GameDone records once.

Signature surface: the **helping-to-owning shift** and the **make-the-load-visible** balancing-sim. It carries Equalize's (g26) "second shift", connects to The Family Map (g57) and Money, Together (g58), and is the direct precursor to Equal Parents (g62) once children arrive.

Even-handed; men as equal owners.

- **Even-handed.** Engages men as equal owners, never anti-men; an equal home is framed as better for everyone.
- **No shaming.** Never shames any couple's current arrangement; it offers a path forward, not blame.
- **Owning, not helping.** The core reframe, from "helping" to owning the planning and remembering, runs throughout.
- **Both careers respected.** Dual-career fairness; whose job flexes is never decided by gender.
- **Coercion routing.** Where inequality becomes coercive or controlling, it routes to Respect at Home (g56) and help.
- **Made-for-India.** Navigates in-laws and joint-family expectations, with the realities of India's large unpaid-care gap.
- **Access & privacy.** Self-directed, audio, offline, low-end build; private by design (DPDP-aligned).

When inequality tips into control (India). Sharing the load fairly is partnership; controlling a partner's money, movement or choices, or coercing them into all the work, is abuse, not just unfairness. That routes to Respect at Home (g56) and help: Women Helpline 181 / women-in-distress 1091 / emergency 112, or a couples counsellor for a struggling partnership. An equal home is happier for everyone, and never a loss for men.

v2 schema, scorecard-gated.

- **gameld. equal-partners** — `node.game === GameDone key === registry id` (confirm exact id in engine-host).
- **v2 mechanic-embodiment schema**. `type + typed payload`; the **branch** ownership choice leads, with a balancing-sim and the helping-to-owning **strike-rewrite** set.
- **Even-handedness is a hard requirement**. Engaging men as equal owners, never anti-men, and never shaming a current arrangement are contractual; expert-reviewed.
- **Fact-checked content**. The mental-load concept, the India unpaid-care gap (around 2.6 times in dual-income homes), and the burnout link verified this build.
- **Scorecard-gated**. Passed all eight checks (7 mechanics, top mechanic at 21%, 0% binary, 29 autonomy, 15 UN→RE, 6 personas, 100% completeness). Re-run `score_gdd.py` on any edit.
- **Help-resource hook**. Coercive inequality routes via the shared "get help" component to Respect at Home (g56) / 181 / 1091 / 112.
- **Tracked**. `build_gate.py` finalize advances g55 to v2 PASS only after order, read, score, audit and artifact gates pass.

Ethics contracts (never traded for engagement): even-handed, men as equal owners; never anti-men; never shames a current arrangement; both careers respected; coercion routing; made-for-India.

Why this works.

- **Naming the invisible load is the breakthrough.** Because the mental load is real, exhausting and largely unseen, making it visible and nameable is the first and biggest step toward sharing it.
- **Owning, not helping, is the real shift.** Since "helping" leaves the manager role with the woman, teaching men to own whole domains, so no one has to remind them, is what actually rebalances the home.
- **Equality is built, renegotiated and good for all.** Because fairness drifts and life changes, an explicit, revisited split, with both careers valued, makes an equal home that is happier and healthier for everyone.

Sources: UNESCO ITGSE gender equality (3.2, 1.1, 5.3); UN Women on unpaid care work and the equal household; India time-use and invisible-labour research (women doing around 2.6 times more unpaid care than men even in dual-income homes; the link between invisible labour and cognitive overload and burnout); and relationship-wellbeing research on equal homes. Even-handed, engaging men as equal owners, never anti-men, never shaming any current arrangement, and routing coercive inequality to Respect at Home (g56) and help. Citations accompany each scenario in the library JSON. 55 games now v2. Next by order: Respect at Home (g56).